

Asker Lane

ii

From Roman Times

by
George Wigglesworth

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COACHES,
To & from LONDON, BIRMINGHAM,
BUXTON, MANCHESTER, NOT-
TINGHAM and SHEFFIELD, pass
through Matlock Bath, daily.

CARRIERS.
To CHESTERFIELD, Thomas Rouse,
from his house, Matlock, every Wed-
nesday and Saturday.
To DERBY, Elizabeth Brinsley, from
her house, Matlock Bath, every Tues.
To SHEFFIELD, Elizabeth Brinsley,
from Matlock Bath, every Friday;
returns on Saturday.
To WIRKSWORTH, Thomas Rouse,
from Matlock, every Mon. and Thurs.

Pigot's Commercial Directory, 1835

Introduction; Hassuc Kjarr

This is very much a draft, the result of some months' investigation and already the area of interest has grown a bit. It sets out to record in full what I have found is documented and it might serve as a starting point, perhaps for others. It is intended mainly to seek responses from those who know differently or better! Already the text has been altered in response to such feedback.

It has almost entirely involved the use of secondary sources. As necessary I rewrite parts and then reprint updated versions if they are requested but that does mean there will be variations and the only clue will be the print date. This is in fact the second edition with attention now given to the Roman period. Imperial measures are used where reporting people who would use such units.

I have already had much appreciated help from many sources including Lynn Willies, Stuart Band, Gladwyn Turbutt, Julie Bunting and Peter Naylor as well as the staff at Derbyshire Records Office and the Local Studies Library. My wife, Margaret, as throughout our married life, has given me re-assurance when I have ventured into print by has correcting the English usage for which I remain grateful.

George Wigglesworth
December 2006



Horsecar Toll Booth

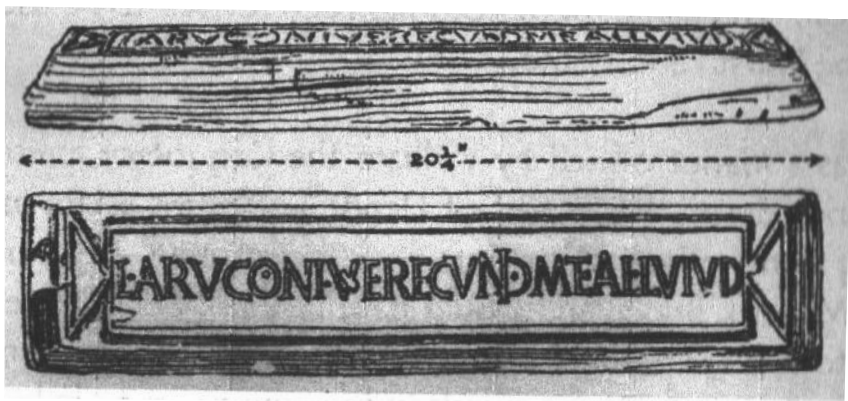
Roman residues

The Roman era is many, many years ago. We seem here to be considering the second and third centuries AD. Unless there is written evidence, with which the north of England is blessed, or engravings, for example those that embellish pots or stellae, then deduction, with all its room for misinterpretation, remains the main tool. Lead smelting and transportation are not very decorative or newsworthy.

It is clear lead was obtained from the Derbyshire field by the Romans and almost certainly before then. 35% of the known Romano-British ingots are from Derbyshire. Although the north side of the Matlock area has no lead deposits nevertheless there are tangible Roman links through lead ingots and thereby their transportation or production. Harry C Monet-Lane's 1986 publication "*The Romans in Derbyshire*" and Lynn Willies are used initially as the source of much of the basic information which follows. Lead ingots that have been found are in fact usually associated with transportation rather than production. The loss of heavy ingots in their transport over wet or boggy places like rivers or moors and so beyond recovery is easily understood in contrast to leaving valuable ingots on smelting sites.

Three lead ingots have been found on the slopes north of Matlock, together with a fourth that was melted down in the belief that it was modern. Here lead ingots were made into oblong pigs and inscribed but elsewhere have been found bearing the imprint of the bowl in the hearth where they were initially smelted. The silver content in each case is very low, a characteristic of lead from Derbyshire. The Victoria County History p228 *et seq* gives a full reference.

1. A pig weighing 38kg was found in 1783 at Map Reference SK 299 614 which corresponds to the northern end of Bent Lane, a continuation of Caven-dish Road. It was inscribed L.ARVCONII. VERECVNDI. METAL. LVTVD. The first part of the inscription could be expanded to be Lucius Aruconius Verecundus, probably the name of a merchant and using names popular in the 1st century AD. (The only Derbyshire ingot which can be firmly dated is one found on Cromford Moor bearing the Emperor Hadrian's name, thus placing it early in the 2nd century.) The last two words indicate mines at Lutudarum whose location is discussed below. It was found a "few inches beneath the surface of the ground, near Matlock Bank, when some recently enclosed common land was being cleared; close by was a 'bole' or ancient smelting hearth of large flat stones." It was first the property of Adam Woolley and



Inscription on the Bent Lane ingot (number 1)
(see Victoria County History p 228)

given by him to the British Museum in 1797. He was listed as occupier of land enclosed by the Enclosure Act. It was on top 49cm x 8.4cm, its base 55cm x 13cm, overall 9.5cm high

2 An ingot weighing 79kg was found in 1787 (after the Enclosure Act) at 320 620 which is on the line of the Chesterfield Road 50 metres NE of Cuckoostone Lane. It is inscribed TI. CL. TR. LVT. BR.EX.ARG. This inscription, it has been suggested, indicates that it was part of the tribute due to Tiberius Claudius but, as we are told this is epigraphically impossible, more probably implies 'mined on behalf of someone with a name such as Tiberius Claudius Tropimus'. BR is an abbreviation for Britannia while Ex Arg indicates its low silver content being of no significance. It was first in the possession of one Mr Molesworth but is now lost..



The Portland Grange ingot (number 3 below)
Copyright Trustees of the British Museum

3 Another ingot was found on 24th March 1894. It was found in the field centred on SK 3186 6177 adjacent to Portland Grange. Walter Kirkland reported in *'Notts and Derbyshire, notes and queries'* June 1894 that it was found by a person working for Daniel Hurd, (owner of the house) who was breaking up the heathland for tillage. His spade struck something hard about two feet below the surface.

The ingot weighed 80kg with a silver content of only 0.022%. Its dimensions were:- on top 50cm x 9 cm, its base 56cm x 13.5cm, overall 11cm high. It is inscribed P. RVBRI. ABASCANTI. METALLI. LVTVDARES. This may be interpreted to mean "Made by P. Rubri Abascanti and from a mine of Lutudarum." This inscription suggests a merchant Publius Rubrius Abascantus. It has been suggested there might have been a furnace nearby.



Inscription on the Portland Grange ingot (number 3)
(see the Victoria County History p 228)

4. In about 1874 a pig of lead or "Roman shape" and inscribed G.A. was found at SK 3261, namel on Tansley Moor, but was melted down at Lea Lead Works as the letters were believed to be modern.

Here the word "hearth" is used to refer to finds where smelting occurred. They might be from boles or furnaces. The lead seems to have been extracted into a bowl-shaped pig and then several were consolidated into an oblong identifiable pig of a suitable weight for transportation to a market or end user. It is very difficult to date hearths unless some datable artefact is incorporated and has been found. A smaller hearth which was also used for making small metallic ornaments for example should be differentiated, remembering also that lead was used in Roman bronze.

Galena, the ore of lead in the form of Lead Sulphide, was smelted. Boles are hearths sited on a hilltop facing the prevailing west or south west wind in order



A 'bowl shaped' ingot such as could come from the Duffield hearth
Courtesy of Lynn Willies

that it would be possible to foresee that the three day "campaign" required for the smelting could be completed. Such boles could be enhanced by foot bellows and these are easily contrived. We know they had been by the Greeks who the Romans would have been able to copy. The boles at Riber and Dethick have a known 16th century history and there is therefore a long, badly documented period involved. At the bole at Scarcliffe (on the magnesian limestone in East Derbyshire) a furnace has been excavated and a Roman coin was found nearby, providing a possible date. Walter Kirkland reported that there were several places on Tansley Moor where the ground was burnt to a dark colour and that slight traces of lead having been molten have been found where it had burnt the roots and remained in the ground. Nearby pigs of lead are the only evidence for a Roman date and two are adjacent to a supposed Roman route. This of course is circumstantial evidence..



A Romano-British hearth at Duffield
Courtesy of Lynn Willies

If the ore was rich as much as 55% could be removed. The slag from this first stage extraction was reheated to claim more of the metal (as much as half that which remained) in a "blackwork oven" usually, but not always, nearby. Whereas "white coal" (dried wood chips) was used in later furnaces for the first stage, charcoal was used in slag extractions.

The transportation of lead is ill documented. The weight of one ingot is less than the load small horses could carry, but loading just one heavy ingot on a horse is difficult to imagine. The Romans, of course, had wheeled vehicles but wheels of heavy carts damaged roadways. Sledges have been recorded, but of what date and for what load? Maybe the loads were trailed on poles as we have seen "Indians" do in films.

The Road Network

The road network is more and more difficult to perceive as one goes back in time. We can be confident there were roads corresponding to the Matlock-Chesterfield road and one Matlock-Tansley-Stretton-Rykneld Strete in the eighteenth century (subject to minor re-routings). For times extending back from there, many theories have been propounded but evidence is hard to come by and, even if a function might be devised, the route is obscure. Routes through Matlock will be considered first, "Herewardstrete" later.

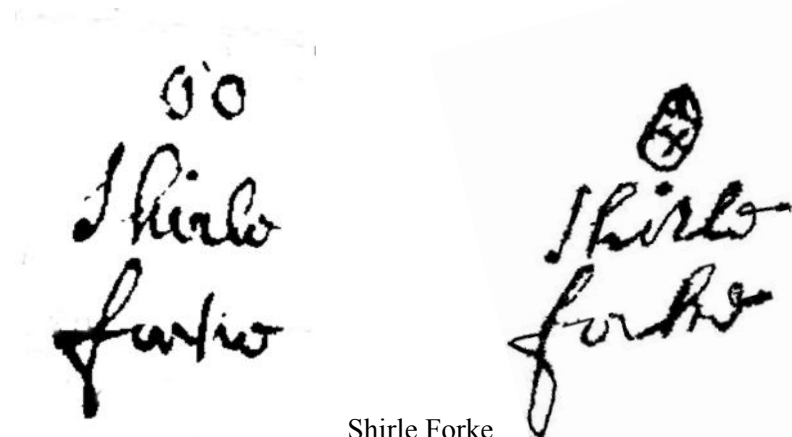
It seems various collection and transportation points were used by the Romans. Brough (1km SE of Hope) was one in the north. The use of the quays on the Trent certainly, and possibly the Derwent, points to Great Wilne (and perhaps Cromford) in the case of more southerly places. Bawtry with its "small Roman fort" was a port connecting with the sea used by north east Derbyshire.

Lutudarum is a Roman place name often used but which cannot be located. It may be a name used for the Derbyshire Lead Field as a whole or its administrative centre such as the large, 3 hectare, Roman fort at Chesterfield. It may have been an important settlement such as Matlock, Middleton by Wirksworth or Carsington where there was a villa. It could have been somewhere important in collection and transportation such as Great Wilne at the confluence of the Derwent with the Trent (or may be Cromford). It is 116km from Matlock via Chesterfield, Bawtry, the River Idle to Stockwith and thence to Brough (the second place with that name) on the Humber (where pigs of lead have been found and which might have been a Roman sea port probably.) The route from Cromford via the Trent was 210km. It is argued that the Romans preferred to

transport heavy loads, such as pigs of lead, by water. However the river Derwent round Matlock and Cromford at least is very turbulent and shoaled and such circumstances make capsizing a heavy load easy. The navigation of rivers by single-masted, man-hauled barges which feature in one vase illustration and if used here must have been slow.

In 1922 a road perhaps Roman was discovered during pipe work laying in Haw (Hall?) Leys leading from Shiplode (under Pic Tor), slanting towards the road now known as Steep Turnpike and found “100m from the crossing from the bridge into Haw Leys”. Shiplode was a name used of fields between Dale Road and the River in a map of 1848 (a name thought to derive from “Sheep Crossing”). The roadway was 8m wide and 4.25m below the existing surface. (One would think that would be very near or even below the river level but the name Causeway Lane shows that, while water level was an issue in that area, it had been solved at least in part.) Reference to laying sewage pipes at this date has been found in the local press, but no reference to this find has been uncovered.

It seems therefore that there are reasons to propose a Roman route from Rocester via Ashbourne, Wirksworth and Matlock to Chesterfield. This route, if through Old Matlock and continuing northwards, seems ill-defined. A river crossing, should it be where Matlock Bridge now is, might link up with Bank Road. A route through Matlock Town or a ford such as Shiplode could link with the present Chesterfield Road route at Matlock Green or with Steep Turnpike or even go through Lumsdale.



Shirle Forke
as shown on a sketch map of 1687 (left) and 1703 (right)

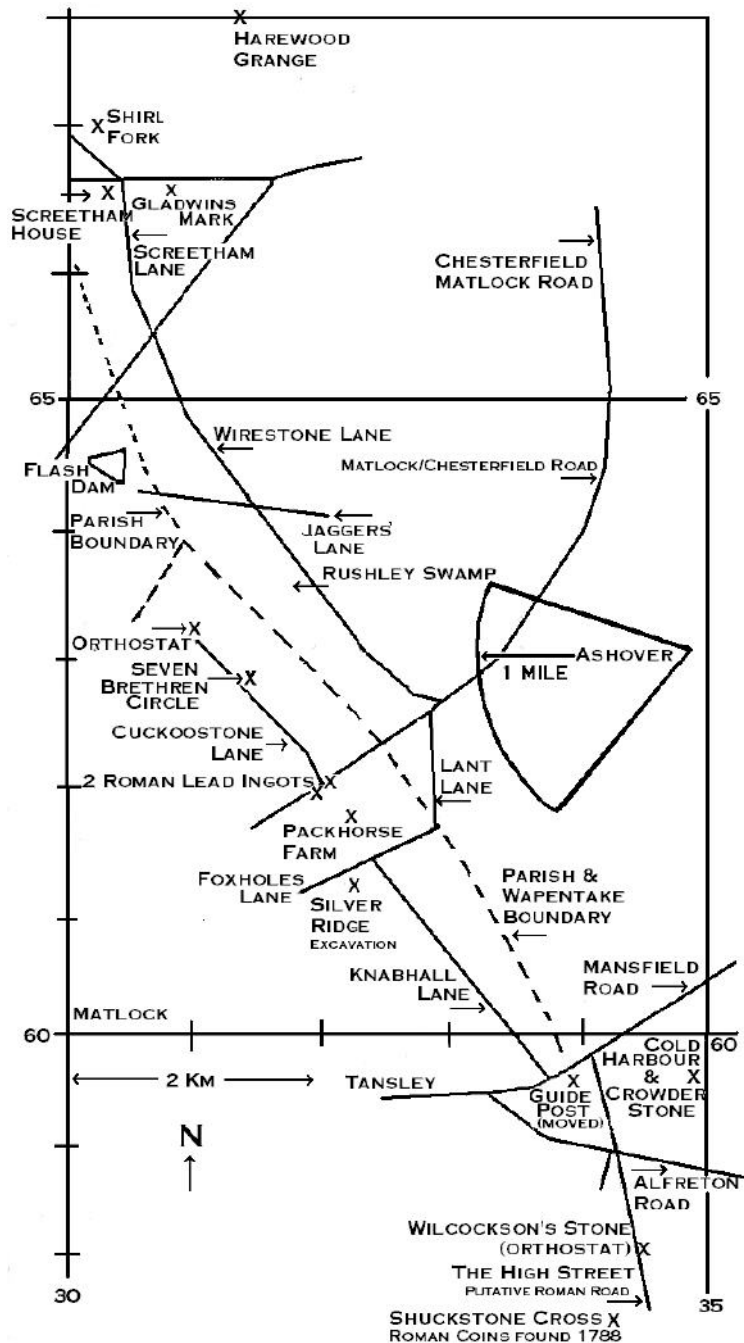
Hereward Street

Hereward Street raises issues of relating documentary evidence with artefacts on the ground in both time and place. Adrian Henstock, writing in the Derbyshire Archeological Journal (1970), discusses the matter. The only early references to it are in four 13th century documents defining grazing rights for Harewood Grange. These refer to Hereward Street at Sirle Forke (a parish boundary mark still used in 1722) which can be confidently placed to the SW and adjacent to Harewood land. Shirle Forke is drawn onto two Ashover Parish Boundary sketch maps (1687 & 1703). A stone called Charles Fork is named in a review (1635) of Beeley parish boundary near Darley Flash in a place where Ashover and Beeley parishes are juxtaposed. It is almost certainly in the neighbourhood of Shirle Forke and may simply be the same landmark

Charles had an early derivation from the Old German “carl” meaning man and Old English “ceorl”. The name was introduced by the Normans but only became popular in Stuart times. It was used to denote a lowly rank of freeman and as such could become incorporated in a formal forename. It is a word cognate with “churl” and thus “churlish”. Thus an alternative explanation might be the extent to which “ceorl”, and from this eventually Charles, might be confused with “Sirle” by the person translating local spoken into written words. Equally Charles may just be the name of a contemporary person with a connection with the locality where the Sirle fork was to be found.



The stone at Shirle Forke



Features of East Moor

“Serlo’s Fork” might refer to a possible fork-shaped piece of land; equally it could refer to the shape made by the junction of the three parishes of Ashover, Beeley, and Darley, even a road or track junction? It could refer to a mediaeval gallows provided by Serlo de Pleasley, which is perhaps the most plausible. “Sirle” is an Old English name used before the Norman conquest and then becoming much more common being a favourite with the Normans before dying out after the 14th century. It is a derivative of “sarva” meaning armour. Forke is used as an early word meaning gallows that being the shape of gallows as far back as Roman times. The name may derive from such a long lost timber structure associated with the stone which survives today.

The use in the medieval documents of *per Hereward Street* to define the grazing is taken to mean “by way of” therefore suggesting a southerly line. Titus Wheatcroft mentions in 1722 three important roads in the parish but these are E-W. S Wooley places it within one mile of Ashover church. It is a matter of conjecture how accurately “one mile” was used. It seems more reasonable to pencil in a line for it generally south-east along East Moor therefore rather than using the name for a SE/NW route from Rocester via Matlock to Chesterfield and which much later, it has been suggested, might have been in part the basis of the Matlock/Chesterfield turnpike. We have therefore a route defined in one place. Extending it back in time and to the south east is alas more contentious. Hereward was a name known in the eleventh century. (Hereward the Wake was a *thegn* in Lincolnshire then.) Street is cognate with Germanic/Scandinavian words but also is used to mean “paved” in Latin. Which of the invasions introduced the usage here is not clear.

East Moor has long been a wet, featureless moor and unless paved roads were established and then persisted, routes would be ill defined and changed for perhaps a presumed drier line. The route can perhaps best be defined as being within a corridor rather than along a line and East Moor is narrowing here so the NE and SW scarp edges delineate the higher ground. This area between the Amber (Hodgelane Brook) and Bentley Brook which would have some drainage at the edge and more sparse, smaller trees suggests the corridor.

Boundaries in such featureless areas often coincide with roads, tracks and footpaths. It is now the boundary between four parishes, for instance the parish of Ashover with Matlock. As well it has been one between Wirksworth Wapentake and Scarsdale Hundred. It may be the boundary between Mercia and Northumbria.

Present day roads may suggest some older routes although parts of roads such as Ryber Road are known to have disappeared and we are familiar with the creation of new roads. The alignments of straight lengths of roads draw attention to them. With that in mind Cuckoostone Lane and Knabhall Lane lie just above the SW edge of the moor while Wirestone Lane is on the NE and thus they are in our “corridor”. Both join up with The High Street suggested as an early, possibly Roman, road which can be tentatively continued along Shuckstone Lane, Plaistow, Potters Lane, Inns Lane to South Wingfield and crossing the Amber to join Ryknield Street at Four Lane Ends. These can be considered in relation to other ancient artefacts such as the Seven Brethren, Wilcockson’s Stone, Shuckstone Cross and the Hasland Post, (of 1709) a guide post (which has, for no good reason, been moved) which was presumably put in a significant place.

Two Roman lead ingots have been found in the area but of course it is not known if they are associated with transport as most Roman ingots with a Derbyshire provenance have been or with production, there being some evidence of smelting thereabouts. There are two Roman links which are more ill defined. At “Silver Ridge” an excavation in about 1970 reportedly found a road thought to be Roman. Unfortunately no report can be found and therefore the precise location, orientation and finds are not known. It could be on the line of Hereward Street. Secondly a few Roman coins were found at Shuckstone Cross in 1788. The cross has been thought to post date the Roman period which leaves the find of earlier coins in need of explanation. Further more the base is at present free standing, and in a place thought by some not ideal as a wayfaring cross so it may at some time have been moved. Is this associated with the find or just another conundrum? The shaft of the cross was found in a wall which had been erected at the time of the enclosure (1777) (and now incorporated into a mantlepiece in Crich). The base has been likened (loosely and not convincingly) to a 17th century mortar or creeing trough.

One can only observe Shuckstone may have been a small settlement of an early date. It features in the Cartulary Documents of Wakebridge near Crich, (transcribed by Avrom Saltman) in the 14th century and in the Domesday survey in the 11th. The name is very variable. Shuck was a demon in Anglo-saxon mythology. Scochetorn is a Norman usage, Shuckthorn is cognate with the usage in 1722 of Chuck Thorn Cross. Avrom Saltman gives transcriptions Shukthorn, Shukethorn, Sukthorn, Schokethorn, Scokthorn from the 13th century.

Packhorse Farm has a name suggesting overnight accommodation for carriers although evidence of a building from before the Enclosure Act (1777) has not been found. Cold Harbour is a name found on Sanderson’s map of Derbyshire (1836) and the original 1” O.S. map surveyed in 1840. Such names are often found on Roman roads when ‘harbour’ derives from ‘*here-beorg*’ or ‘army camp/shelter’. The place name experts however seem to be saying that there are numerous cases where such names occur on hilltops and simply mean ‘shelter’ as in the coastal usage. Can this site be considered a “hilltop?”

To summarise a route from Rocester via Ashbourne and Matlock to Chesterfield may be likely but was probably not called Hereward Street, a name more possibly used for a route going NW to SE along the edge of East Moor. It is probably safest to limit ourselves to envisaging pre-nineteenth -century routes across these moors as “sinuous routes and often ‘braided’ - that is, interlinking on land that was once open waste and common, where a succession of alternative routes could be taken to avoid the worst of the boggy ground” as John Barnatt and Tom Wilkinson write in “Chatsworth, a landscape history” So it is all obscure and conjectural but at least we have the lead ingots!

The Operation of Turnpikes

This was an early example of privatisation intended to improve the quality of roads by making more money become available. In 1760 an Act of Parliament gave Trustees the power to take over the existing route and land of the High Road between Chesterfield and Matlock. Goods traffic was the *raison d’être* for later turnpikes such as this. Thus the local gentry and local merchants were encouraged to sponsor the appropriate Act, provide the necessary venture capital and secure the mortgages. In this case the sum raised was almost £11,000 at 5%/annum, giving £550/annum interest. The Trustees were empowered to charge tolls to balance the capital and ongoing costs, making them commercially attractive as enterprises where the tolls, for example, could provide security for loans. Locally contracts could be agreed for frequent use of turnpikes, for example, to take the lead ore, galena, to be smelted at cupolas.

In the event in one year in the first quarter of the century the tolls taken at the Asker Lane and Amber toll bars were given as a combined figure of as little as £40 (out of an overall total of £420.) In 1874 the takings at Asker Lane were estimated to be £125 but the repairs averaged, over three years for this stretch cost £160/year of which the town contributed £37. Turnpikes proved a very poor investment except in the few cases, unlike this one, where they covered long stretches of road.

This was so poor an investment the interest appears to have been paid as much as 15 years after it was due. However in that turnpike trusts had to apply for the Act of Parliament to be renewed after 21 years in force, outstanding debts were an argument for such a renewal. If it was not renewed there was no chance the debts would ever be repaid. A separate benefit, however, was the way they enhanced the value of property and facilitated businesses such as the operation of mills, mines, smelters and farms for local landowners.

The Trustees and Management Committees responsible for the Matlock/Chesterfield part often met at the Angel Inn in Chesterfield but sometimes the venue alternated with the Falcon and Commercial Inns. The Angel Inn (near the Market and next to the Post Office) was said to be the best hotel in the town and a coaching house already centuries old. It had three billiard tables, many bedrooms and stabling for 250 (*sic*) horses.

The Trustees' minutes do not demonstrate the extent to which expenses could be a valuable perquisite for those involved and which were given a prior claim on the takings; "jobs for the boys". Lawyers were needed to pursue legal matters, inspections justified expenses, the 21 year renewal necessitated journeys to London and lengthy legal exercises.



The Angel Hotel, Chesterfield

Toll gathering could be kept in the hands of the Trustees but in this case they were let out for a designated sum to a person who collected the tolls and stood any loss or pocketed any profit that year. In 1760 Isaac Bowne of Ashover seems to have been awarded the toll contract for the entire route. Often the Walton Tolls were dealt with separately. When, as in 1829, there was no bid, then the overall package of the others was split into two parcels. One can imagine that, when the takings for a previous year had been announced, there would be opportunity for collusion by potential bidders agreeing (for some consideration) to allow an unopposed bid. (Contracts of £400-£550 overall were usually generated.) There were four gates between Matlock and Chesterfield and three on the branch to Darley Dale and one to Rowsley. It seems doubtful that there was ever one at the bottom of Steep Turnpike and the suggested house there is rather elaborate to be one. It is never mentioned in minutes or shown on maps of the turnpike and could have been where extra horses were kept to pull loads up the steep road.

The transport of lead is specifically mentioned with reference to taking lead ore from Winster to be smelted at Harewood and would be significant in Matlock, for example, with respect to the cupola in Lumsdale. The main inland port at the head of a river system for transport of the lead produced at that time was Bawtry and when the Chesterfield canal was opened in 1777 that became the important intermediary. Prior to that the Alfreton turnpike was an alternative route competing for users. The roads to Winster and beyond via Two Dales (here called Toadhole) Darley Dale and to Rowsley were opened from the turnpike at Stone Edge in the first year of the turnpike. There were five turnpikes radiating from Matlock and this one stimulated an Act five years later for a connection from it to Ashover (significantly also an important source of lead ore) and for a network round there which connected with two other toll roads.

The turnpike would have been very significant in the lives of the locals. In Leeds riots were fired on, causing more than thirty to be wounded, some fatally. The complexities of using it must have mystified people as much as the payment for taking wagons or cattle on their local road, which they had used without charge from time immemorial, would anger them. This explained why initial Acts were limited to a 21 year period, but no doubt the chance of this renewal was never discussed.

The fees depended upon the number of horses pulling the vehicle. An ox counted as half a horse! Wheels less than 6" wide increased the fee because

narrow wheels cut up the roads even more than wider ones. Organic fertiliser for the fields was free, but lime was not. Corn going to the mill was free, unless you were the miller. The man who used six horses to pull a narrow-wheeled cart was fined. The toll-gate keeper who failed to lock the bar at night was just sacked. Cattle going to the fields were free unless it was more than two miles. Toll houses had to be instituted or resited to catch those going round the back streets to escape the tolls and some country roads were ordered to be closed to prevent them offering an alternative free route. No wonder it was necessary to offer rewards for information about those avoiding tolls. Going to church was free! At least it was initially; this exemption was removed later. The carriage of prisoners or vagrants was free too! There was an exemption for wagons accompanying soldiers and for post horses.

The Buxton/Manchester turnpike tolls referred to a Coach, Chariot, Chaise or Calash and differentiated according to the number of horses drawing it. In 1823 tolls for commercial use on the Matlock-Chesterfield turnpike were as tabulated here.

For every horse, mule or other beast drawing any coach &c	4d
Any wagon using wheels of the breadth of 6 in.	4d
Ditto less breadth than 6 in.	6d
For every horse, mule or other beast laden or unladen and not drawing	1½d
For every drove of oxen, cows or neat cattle [<i>“neat” here means ox-like, an ox, bullock, cow or heifer. Ed.</i>] (calves excepted) per score	10d
For every drove of calves, hogs, sheep, lambs, per score	5d
For every carriage with wheels of breadth 6in. or upwards loaded with any millstone, blocks of stone, or timber and drawn by 5 horses	2s 6d
For each horse exceeding that number	1s 0d
For every carriage with wheels of less breadth than 6in. and loaded as aforesaid	3s 9d
For each horse exceeding 5	1s 0d

Pedestrians were free and a wicket gate might be there for their use but those driving pack animals could use it to bypass payment at the tollbar. The toll was paid once and could be used that day repeatedly and at other tollbars on that road. As time passed the tolls became more and more complicated as refinements and exceptions were added. Toll bars were required to display the charges (but often failed to do so) and the photograph of the Asker Lane booth seemingly has a long board to the left of the door which could have been intended for this purpose.

There were all sorts of regulations: they applied to the season when roads were to be watered to settle dust, the location of windmills which initially were to be 200 yards away from the road (later 50 and the position of the windmill at Spitewinter reflects this), the use of fireworks on or near roads was prohibited. Both the latter it seemed might frighten horses, You could not bait a bull on the turnpike either. There were fines instituted, for example for unhitching horses at the toll bar, thus reducing the toll due. Others, for the same reason, used pack animals to negotiate the toll bar, operating a shuttle service between two wagons.

Toll Cottages could have enclosed land up to one eighth of an acre for a garden as we know Asker Lane Toll Bar had. It had been leased to the Rev J Higgs, possibly the John Higgs on the tithe map of 1848, the owner of Asker Farm which was occupied by John Yeomans. It was, however, said to have been sold for £30 to Rev W Higgs when the turnpike trust was wound up in 1880.

Maintenance of the Turnpikes

The income from letting the tolls was much less (say £400) than the £850 cost of repairs in 1841, on top of which there was the interest on the mortgage which was £550. Perhaps most significant to the villagers of Matlock would be the statutory duty to maintain the roads in the parish and to contribute as much as two thirds to the cost. A system of *corvée* was used, that is to say there was a duty to perform work for no pay for a limited number of days. This duty was imposed by the "Statute for Mending Highways" in 1555 and was only revoked as late as 1835 by the General Highway Act, thus covering the early years of the turnpike era. The Trustees required the Surveyors of Highways in each parish or residential “quarter” to report the names of those having this duty, in the case of Matlock to provide half a day’s work and in other parishes up to three days. Surveyors who “refused or neglected” to report the names were recorded in the minutes and they were penalised. The demand that 'they should mend their ways' required householders to provide free labour or the use of a horse and cart. The problems of the system caused some trustees to “farm out” the task for adjacent farmers to achieve. Brampton “compounded” their work which seems to have involved payment *in lieu*. Other parishes undertook the maintenance for which they received a payment; in 1812 in Matlock for example, of £10.

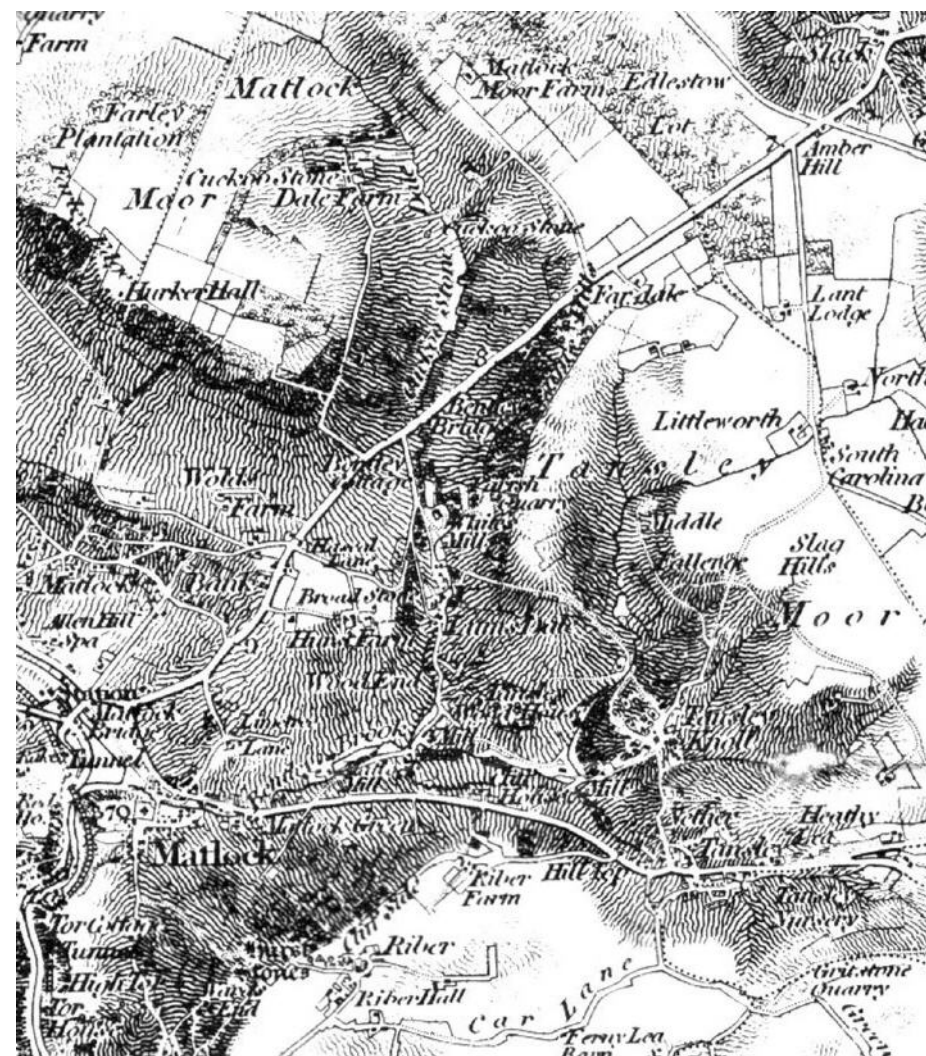
The heavy use necessitated continuous repair of the hilly section of the turnpike into Matlock. Matlock was highly criticised in 1816 for not “wholly or judiciously” expending the money. The drains were not cleared; there was the use of bad materials, using large, unbroken stone; it was accused of putting good material on the bad surface of the wet and dirty road. The Trustees that year met at the Old Bath, which would have allowed them to see the problem, and they resolved to pay Matlock Parish only £5, half the usual sum. In 1841 the need for repairs, particularly round Matlock Bridge, was acted on by the Trustees (when the town failed to act) invoking a Statute to reclaim the cost from the town.

Repairs to the Matlock toll house at Asker Lane cost 5/9^d in 1808; in 1848 roof repairs, which George Derbyshire did, cost 6/3^d and in 1814 John Greaves received payment for repairs to the gate there. Later in the decade decisions were made to install windows and, later shutters, in toll houses that didn’t have them. In 1817 repairs and a cow house cost £5-6-0. In 1834 Wm Hawley erected a new tollgate and in the following years a new pair of posts. In 1846 £4 was the cost when Daniel Hurd built a privy. One is tempted to imagine what happened before! The picture of the toll booth shows what might well be the privy or the entrance to the cow house.. A new oven was provided in 1857 and a new fireplace in 1864.

In 1868 the Trustees were advised by the Surveyor to install a chain at the Hascar Lane Toll Booth to control the numerous users of the road and presumably thus facilitate collecting tolls. “Asker Lane” was a name used in 1868 but “Hascar Lane” was the one still being used in 1880. The Ordnance Survey in 1876 wrote against this tollbar “Matlock Bank T P”).

In 1772 Thomas De Quincey’s father wrote that on approaching Matlock Vale from the direction of Chesterfield: *There are four miles of road over a very extensive moor, covered in some places with fern, but every wherewith large stones sticking out of the earth, and exhibiting a black, desolate and melancholy appearance; the hills are not comparable in height to the mountains of several northern counties, or even to some in more western parts of this: however they are steep enough to oblige any but a daring traveller to alight and walk down, and at the foot of most a brook or rather small torrent pours impetuously along. Nature seems also to have debarred improvements in this dreary waste, having placed an insurmountable object in the way of cultivation, by fixing upon it those prominent rocks.*

We can see there was a very different picture of Derbyshire in times past!



1st Edition Ordnance Survey 1864